In fact, though, they almost became allies in the formal sense when in the wake of 9/11, within hours of the attack, India offered the US 'everything', as American forces prepared to intervene in Afghanistan. Everything included overflight rights, logistics, and basing.[35] Where China had helped the US after 9/11 diplomatically and with some intelligence sharing, India had offered actual alliance-like military cooperation. In the event, Islamabad's support for the Afghanistan invasion was vital, and so Washington politely refused Delhi's offer. However, in February–March 2003, it was the US that came calling, asking for Indian troops to operate in Iraq alongside coalition forces in case of war with Saddam Hussein. Despite uneasiness over US actions there, and a parliamentary resolution deploring it, Delhi gave serious thought to putting 'boots on the ground', before eventually saying no.[36]

While India and the US did not ally on Afghanistan and Iraq, there remained US interest in cultivating Delhi for the long term. In 2000, Condoleezza Rice, the Stanford professor who would go on to be George W. Bush's NSA, wrote in the journal *Foreign Affairs*: 'India is an element in China's calculation, and it should be in America's, too. India is not a great power yet, but it has the potential to emerge as one.'[37] Five years later, this line of thinking produced a declaration that the two countries would aim for 'full civilian nuclear cooperation', at the heart of which was an agreement that India would identify its civilian nuclear reactors, separate them from the military ones, and open them to international regulation. The separation of reactors would pave the way for the resumption of nuclear collaboration, which had been stopped after India's 1974 nuclear tests. India, for its part, accepted a continued moratorium on testing and other standard non-proliferation norms and practices. In 2008, the two sides unveiled and signed the final accord which would get US congressional and international approval. The deal in essence gave India access once again to advanced nuclear technology and scientific interactions and yet protected its military reactors and programme. It also formed the basis for greater diplomatic trust between India and the US. India's nuclear programme had